

Cracks in our Metaverse

AS THE METAVERSE TAKES SHAPE AND VR EXPERIENCES COME TO LIFE ALL AROUND US, I CAN'T SAY I'M NOT EXCITED ABOUT WHAT IT ALL POSSIBLY ENTAILS. The hype train suggests we're all going to be inside playable games, heroes and heroines of our own movies alongside our friends, and other flights of fancy inconceivable for my poor imagination. A digital age fuelled by the new Internet on steroids.

In terms of technology, the confluence of three things is enabling the Metaverse behind-the-scenes. The rise of high-performance computing in the cloud, easily accessible network bandwidth (5G and beyond) and constantly improved end-user devices, all of which are going to unleash hyper interactivity on an unprecedented virtual scale – at least that's what all the early hype indicates. Imagine being a character inside one of your favourite video games (Assassin's Creed) or donning Iron Man's avatar or interacting with other superheroes inside an Avengers movie? Experience Sim City, Second Life or Minecraft on steroids. Endless possibilities inside hyper-personal storylines where there are no losers, only winners. We may have dreamed of such things in the past, but they are inevitable and just around the corner. If only I were a teenager with no care in the world and hours at my disposal!

Even as 3D virtual environments begin to leap out of our PC browsers, smartphone apps and HMDs, demanding every ounce of our attention for maximum immersion, some of the cracks are already visible on the fringes of the Metaverse. And they're serious enough to start raising an alarm.

In December 2021, reports of women's digital 3D avatars being "groped" in the Metaverse grabbed headlines. There's no precedent for such behaviour on the Internet, where a woman's modesty was violated to such an extent despite people's lowered online inhibitions and exploitative anonymity. Beyond simple words or toxic text confined to the comments section of a piece of video or someone's social media handle, this type of 3D virtual assault goes beyond the confines of "normal" online bullying or cyber harassment that people struggle to cope with in the first place. Imagine if this becomes the new, twisted online normal? Where increasingly reckless online behaviour had no real-world consequences on the perpetrators?

In February 2022, a BBC investigation revealed how certain Metaverse apps were already "dangerous by design", especially for kids and teens. Young girls getting subjected to racist, sexist abuses and rape threats. Some of these virtual environments have digital clubs, where people's 3D avatars exhibit sexually suggestive behaviour around items like dancing poles and removing their clothes to showcase nudity. Gambling zones with games such as poker and roulettes can be easily accessed by minors behind 3D avatars, if left to roam this unsavoury expanse of the Internet's underbelly masquerading under a new "Metaverse" buzzword.

Not quite to this extreme, but I accidentally experienced this vast, unmoderated online frontier through the curiosity of my daughter. Before I watched *Squid Games*' (in)famous *Red Light Green Light* episode, my daughter told me the game's rules and what happens to players who fail to complete it – spoiler alert, they die gruesome deaths – all thanks to a playable Roblox version of the Netflix series. Her unintentional exposure to 3D graphic violence while trying to play an unsuspecting game made me reassess my parental responsibilities. In some ways, it shook my confidence for letting my ward access online environments that aren't as safe as I thought they were.

Whether anti-social, unguarded behaviour is manifesting on popular gaming platforms or at the edges of several disparate Metaverse entities taking shape right now, they're no doubt highlighting some of the user behavioural risks this new Metaverse-fuelled Internet will have to mitigate. When everyone from Meta to Microsoft, from the biggest of Big Tech to the smallest of startups are building and shaping the future of their Metaverses, user safety and privacy will have to be a non-negotiable prerequisite for making these virtual environments appealing to people of all ages to come along on the ride.

I'm no doomsday prophet and I remain open-minded and optimistic about the Metaverse's potential for good, even though I may not see it at this early stage of its evolutionary curve. But every developer and tech conglomerate who's harping the Metaverse tune would do well to ask themselves: just because we could, doesn't mean we should, and understand that every action can have unforeseen reactions. Or else the Metaverse will remain a crude version of art imitating life and lots of unfulfilled potential. **d**



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